Only Humayun, writes Gulbadan, ‘was far ahead’ – was he racing to save his own skin, or that of his wife and unborn child? At any rate, a galloping horse soon overtook him – did he wonder, perhaps, if this was the end? – but it was only a messenger from his men: somehow, the Mughal soldiers had fought off the attack. For now, they were safe; and there was even a bit of water nearby.

For the second time that day, Humayun got off his horse, and for the second time, there was the dust of horsemen on the horizon. Another cry: ‘God forbid! Maldeo!’[43]

But no, it was only Tardi Beg, Munim Khan and the others, catching up with the camp. Finally, the thirsty, dusty exiles were able to drink in peace. They would find no more water for the next three days.

According to Jouher’s account, this was not so much from a lack of wells, but because Maldeo had deputed his men to ride ahead of Humayun’s party and fill the wells in their path with sand. The raja’s intention, it seems, was to punish Humayun for allowing his men to capture and kill cows and buffaloes during their march. The raja sent two messengers to say so: having known that ‘the killing of kine was forbidden in Hindu districts’ and having ‘nevertheless killed a number of these sacred animals’, Humayun ‘must take the consequences’.[44]

The consequences were dire. The exiles were specks in the endless sands of Jaisalmer; it was August and the sun rose ferociously high, day after day, in skies that held not a hint of rain. For three days they walked, sipping at their meagre reserves, and when, on the fourth, the company finally found some wells that held water, men and women threw themselves at the buckets that were hauled up, some with such force that they fell tumbling into the wells head first.

Nizamuddin the historian presents an even more pathetic picture. A bullock was used to draw out water, sunk so deep that you had to beat a drum when the buckets reached the rim, ‘a call would not reach’ the bullock driver. With water so close, this last, sluggish journey was too much for some to bear. As soon as the drumbeat sounded, they threw themselves at the well, thus breaking the rope and sending the longed-for bucket crashing into the dark, far below. Imagine the scene. ‘Cries and lamentations’ broke out, and some who could bear it no more ‘cast themselves intentionally into